



UNIT: HHE2206
EAST AFRICAN STUDIES

CAT 2 TAKE AWAY ASSIGNMENT

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1. Political Challenges

(a) Corruption

Corruption has sadly been the biggest challenge for both Kenya and Uganda. It has led to significant amounts of the national resources go to waste to leaders that are only willing to benefit themselves. This has significantly stunted the growth of both countries.

(a) Lack of Experience

Many of the political leaders had spent years fighting for independence and had little or no experience in governing a nation. This lack of experience led to difficulties in effectively managing the country and making detrimental decisions.

(b) Terrorism

From rogue Somali pirates to numerous attacks on malls, universities and embassies, Kenya and Uganda have had the burden of insecurity as a result of the political unstable Somalia nation.

(b) Ethnic Divisions

Kenya comprises more than 40 different tribes, unfortunately majority of this tribes vote only for leaders that belong to their tribes or have made alliances with their tribe leaders. This has led to political instability I.e leading to the 2007 post election violence and therefore making it challenging to establish a united and inclusive nation.

(c) Broken Electoral system

From ambitious leaders being assassinated to rigged elections which have lead to corrupt officials gaining power. Kenya and Uganda need to fix their electoral systems in order to make allow corrupt leaders to be removed from power.

(d) Socialism

Tanzania's early socialist Ujamaa policies (villagization, nationalization) sought equity but reduced agricultural productivity and growth; fiscal strain and inefficiencies followed.

(e) Oppressive regimes

Kenya, Uganda and Tanzania have had leaders which have abused their powers to eliminate peaceful protests or healthy opposition. From targeted arrests, abusing human rights activists, journalists and spying on Lecturers and much more this has lead to a dictatorial and corrupt regime.

Economic Challenges

(a) Debt

Kenya's has significantly increased its Debt to GDP ratio via international borrowing. Moreover this loans have been with a high interest rate compared to what their European counterparts are loaned. If this trend continues as well as increased corruption the country is likely to file for bankruptcy or have a economic recession.

(a) Lack of mineral reserves

Kenya has significantly fewer mineral reserves compared to its neighbors I.e Tanzania and South Africa. Uganda has copper reserves which have since been depleted. This has made countries such as South Africa have a bigger advantage over Kenya

(b) Youth unemployment and informalization

Rapid population growth created a youthful labor force with insufficient formal jobs—leading to large informal sectors, underemployment, and urban poverty.

(c) Dependency and colonial economic legacies

Economies structured around export of a few primary commodities (coffee,tea, cash crops, minerals), vulnerable to price shocks and lacking industrial diversification.

Moreover, colonial companies I.e tea processing factories still exist and charge high costs to process the tea for local farmers.

(d) Structural Adjustment Programs (SAPs) and social costs

In the 1980s–1990s, IMF/World Bank funding conditionalities forced liberalization, privatization, and spending cuts. These stabilized macro-economies but deepened unemployment, reduced access to services, and increased poverty vulnerability.

Social Challenges

(b) Limited access to education and skilled workforce

Racial discrimination and inequality were significant social challenges faced by Kenya after gaining independence. The legacy of colonialism had left deep-rooted racial divisions, with certain communities facing discrimination and marginalization. This hindered social cohesion and created a sense of injustice among various ethnic groups. Also Tanzania and Uganda's educational systems have lagged behind Kenya's system.

(c) Land distribution and ownership

Land distribution and ownership was another social challenge that Kenya had to address in its early years of independence. Large tracts of land were owned by a small elite group, while the majority of the population had limited access to land for agriculture and housing. This unequal distribution of land created social and economic disparities and fueled tensions within the society. Post independence this has still been an issue in Africa as some families still own tracts of Land equivalent to countries.

(d) Diseases and epidemics

Kenya, Uganda and Tanzania have lost a lot due to diseases and epidemics. From a high HIV/AIDS percentage of plaguing the 3 countries to Corona Virus which lead the loss of educated and innovative citizens.

(e) Education and health gaps

Progress in primary education (notably Tanzania after UPE policies) but uneven quality, low secondary enrollment, and skills gaps for industrial jobs. HIV/AIDS epidemic (1980s–2000s) had severe demographic, social, and economic impacts—reduced life expectancy, orphanhood, pressure on health systems. Later public-health responses improved outcomes but challenges remain.

Environmental and demographic pressures

(a) Population growth and urbanization

Rapid urban expansion produced informal settlements, strained infrastructure, and service delivery problems. This has led to growth of slums and made Tanzanians, Kenyans and Ugandans even more reliant on foreign aid.

(b) Climate change and resource stress

Recurrent droughts, soil degradation, water scarcity, and shifting rainfall patterns have undermined agriculture and pastoralist livelihoods, intensifying competition and migration. Also El-nino and La-nina have led to breakage of dams i.e. Solai dam and drought and famine have heavily reduced farm output and led to loss of lives i.e. Turkana.

(c) Natural-resource conflicts

Discovery of oil (Uganda, off-shore prospects) and competition over grazing/water have raised governance challenges and risks of elite capture. Somali has also been in conflict with Kenya about the end of their coastline and therefore fishing grounds and potential oil fields. Also Ethiopia has attacked Kenyan fishermen over their fishing grounds in Turkana.

Negative ethnicity in Kenya that culminated in the 2007–2008 post-election violence:

- 1. Highly contested election result:** Widespread perception that the December 2007 presidential vote count and announcement were manipulated—especially among supporters of opposition candidate Raila Odinga.
- 2. Rapid elite fragmentation:** Politicians immediately framed the dispute in ethnic terms; protests and counter-mobilization followed along community lines.
- 3. Economic Inequality and Marginalization -** Uneven regional development favored certain ethnic homelands e.g. Central Kenya , producing resentment among excluded groups.
- 4. Weak institutions and impunity:** Judiciary, police and electoral bodies lacked full independence and credibility; corruption and selective enforcement heightened perceptions of bias.
- 5. Electoral rules and winner-takes-all incentives:** First-past-the-post and a strong executive created high stakes for control of the presidency; losing groups feared exclusion from rents and security.
- 6. Land and historical grievances:** Colonial land dispossession and uneven post-independence redistribution created long-standing disputes between people that live along the Rift Valley, Central and Coast. Landlessness and insecurity concentrated along ethnic and regional lines.
- 7. Political party formation and deformation:** Parties often formed and dissolved based on ethnic ties and not political ideology this made it harder for Kenyans to join a party if the members were not part of their community.
- 7. Ethnic militias and youth gangs:** Prior episodes (e.g., 1992, 1997) showed elites could mobilize youth and militia networks for intimidation and violence; these networks were dormant but reactivated in 2007.